

With *System Shock* as a spiritual predecessor and new-age cutting edge visual and aural tools at its disposal, *BioShock* was never for the faint-hearted.

After your plane crash, you'll swim to a beacon from a lighthouse that seems to serve no apparent purpose in the middle of an ocean, descending via a rusty bathysphere to Rapture. Once there you'll navigate around—guided by a mysterious voice, a man who seems to have his own reasons for keeping you around... for the time being at least.

Rapture, the creation of maniacal businessman Andrew Ryan, is a city of the future... completely capitalist and free from government interference and religious limitations. In its bloom it might well have been idealistic, but something goes horribly, irreversibly wrong. The city's in disrepair as genetic mutants called Splicers roam around attacking on sight, or on sound. The fight is now for a powerful and corrupting substance called ADAM. This substance is what makes genetic mutation possible, what the fight is all about. It gives men god-like powers—like the ability to shoot out lightning bolts and fireballs from your fingertips, create cyclones or even move objects by sheer force of will (read telekinesis). Such powers are available by injecting tonics called plasmids. You can come across these plasmids or purchase them from vending machines, ADAM being the currency. There's another genetic substance called EVE, which is the charge required to use your powers, and you'll have a bar displaying the current reserve of EVE in your body. An EVE top-up is an injection away. You'll also get the old-fashioned firearms and melee wrench which you can find lying around, or purchase from vending machines with cold cash.

And this is what makes *BioShock*'s combat unique: weapons used in conjunction with ADAM + EVE make for some pretty memorable fights. Imagine freezing an enemy solid and whacking him with your wrench till he breaks into a thousand icy shards. Or imagine what you could do with your fireballs when you chance upon a group of opponents caught flat footed on an oil slick... Alternatively you could send out a swarm of vicious insects to sting antagonists and while they're busy swatting and shrieking pop 'em one in the head...

Enemy variety is lacking, and for the most you'll be battling varieties of Splicers—Lead-heads, Spider Splicers, Houdini Splicers and so on. You will come across small mutated girls called "Little Sisters" who harvest ADAM from dead bodies and store it within their bodies. You'll face a moral dilemma—rip them open for a sizeable amount of precious ADAM, or exorcise them to restore them to their human

selves, thereby saving them for half the ADAM. Before you decide, however, you will face their guardians—"Big Daddies." These huge, hulking guardians seem like proverbial tortoises that couldn't dodge a wheelchair, but attack them and they'll come at you with the speed and impact of a bullet train. Kill them, however, and you'll have Little Sister and all her ADAM at your disposal.

You'll follow the regular mission-style theme throughout levels, all the while indulging in ADAM, sometimes performing tasks for more than one master as you continuously refer to audio logs to discover for yourself what exactly went wrong.

Visually, *BioShock* is splendid enough to keep all but the extremely myopic hooked. The water effects make *Half Life 2* look like a woody cartoon... Fire and explosions look very real, as does the (sometimes) flickering lighting; this adds to the grim ambience the game intentionally sets. And its not just the pixel shading goodness you'll notice: this game has a darn good aural experience in store as well. You'll hear enemies moving around at times, but won't be able to pinpoint their exact location—only the general vicinity they populate. This is intentional, and keeps you always on guard, on edge. Play it after dark

with the lights off, and you'll jump at indistinguishable sounds, while the more mundane ones add to the immersive realism that'll spoil you silly.

BioShock is a unique game that mixes the 1960s with sci-fi themes of bio-genetic mutation and self-modification. Throw in a deep storyline with the freedom to interact with the world as you choose, and unique first-person action that mixes mundane weapons with not so mundane super powers, and you have a recipe for a real thriller. Add a dash of stunning visual graphics and a realistic audio component and you've got a winner. This one is a dish best served hot. It's not sans flaws though—enemy AI, unrealistic weapon damage models, and the fact that its too darn easy. Of course it requires a behemoth of a PC to run as well: 2K Games wasn't kidding when they ideally recommended a GeForce 8800GTX / Radeon HD2900XT card.

Even if you aren't the idealism swilling, dystopian kind of Ayn Rand fan, you should give *BioShock* a try... It's sure to zap your senses.

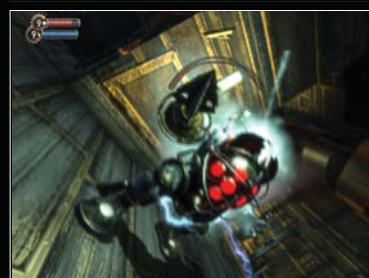
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The dance of death!



Hey... I'm no Tyson... get outta my face...



Time to drill you a new one...



Lookit all that ADAM...mmmm



Ouch!



Rapture is sprawling—and you get to poke around...